# CHOOSING A HEALTHCARE REPRESENTATIVE: WHAT TO CONSIDER

One of the most important decisions you can make as part of your end-of-life planning has nothing to do with medical treatments, legal documents, or funeral arrangements.

It is deciding who will speak for you when you cannot speak for yourself.

Many people assume that because they have a spouse, adult child, or close family member, the decision is obvious. But choosing a Healthcare Representative deserves careful thought.

This individual may one day be asked to make some of the most difficult decisions of their life—decisions about treatments, care plans, quality of life, and honoring your wishes during a medical crisis.

The right choice can provide peace of mind for everyone involved. The wrong choice can create confusion, conflict, and unnecessary stress during an already challenging time.

## WHAT IS A HEALTHCARE REPRESENTATIVE?

A Healthcare Representative is a person you legally designate to make healthcare decisions on your behalf if you become unable to make or communicate those decisions yourself.

In Indiana, a Healthcare Representative may be authorized to:

- Receive medical information
- Communicate with healthcare providers
- Consent to or refuse treatments





## WHY THIS DECISION MATTERS

Imagine your family gathered around a hospital bed.

Doctors are asking questions.

Decisions need to be made.

Emotions are running high.

In that moment, your Healthcare Representative becomes the person responsible for ensuring your wishes are heard and respected. Without clear guidance, family members may disagree about what should happen. Some may want every possible treatment. Others may prioritize comfort and quality of life. The Healthcare Representative helps provide clarity during uncertain times.

## THE MOST COMMON MISTAKE PEOPLE MAKE

Many people choose the person closest to them emotionally. While that may be the right choice, it is not always. The person you love most is not necessarily the person best equipped to serve in this role. Instead of asking:

"Who am I closest to?"

Consider asking:

"Who can best advocate for my wishes, even when it is difficult?"

The answer may surprise you.

## QUALITIES TO LOOK FOR IN A HEALTHCARE REPRESENTATIVE

### SOMEONE WHO CAN REMAIN CALM UNDER PRESSURE







Healthcare Representative • Indiana Death Doula • Indiana Advanced Directives

